

» FIFA WORLD CUP SPECIAL PRE-TOURNAMENT UPDATES



Injuries galore ahead of World Cup

The World Cup has not yet begun, but its first battles are already being fought in treatment rooms.

Kylian Mbappé's (**in pic**) hamstring injury has given France an early scare, even if there is no suggestion yet that its captain will miss the tournament. For a player whose game is built on speed, the timing is awkward. France will hope the setback is only a pause, not a shadow over its campaign.

Argentina has a similar concern in Cristian Romero. The Tottenham centre-back's knee injury has disrupted his build-up, and while there is hope he can recover in time, it is far from ideal preparation for a defender so central to Lionel Scaloni's system. Spain will also be closely monitoring Lamine Yamal's (**below**) recovery, while Egypt has had to manage Mohamed Salah's hamstring issue ahead of the finals.

For others, the wait is already over. Brazil has taken two heavy blows, with Rodrygo ruled out after a knee injury and Eder Militao set to miss the World Cup following hamstring surgery. The Netherlands will be without Xavi Simons after an ACL rupture — a cruel setback for one of its most creative young players.

France has also lost Hugo Ekitike, whose Achilles injury ended his hopes, while Germany will be without Serge Gnabry after an adductor tear. Injuries are part of every World Cup cycle, but the 2026 build-up has already stripped teams of speed, invention, defensive authority and big-stage experience.

Canada keeps Fan Festival access open

A World Cup Fan Festival is meant to feel like a public square, and Toronto has moved closer to that ideal.

After initially proposing a \$10 general admission fee, the city has revised its plan and restored free entry following criticism that the charge went against its promise of a 'free and inclusive' fan space.

The festival will be held at Fort York National Historic Site and The Bentway, featuring live match screenings, entertainment, food and fan activities throughout the tournament. General admission will be free, though advance online registration will be required.

The revised model still includes some crowd control measures, but the message is clear: for most fans, Canada's World Cup experience outside the stadium will not begin at the payment gate.

